

GPUs or research scale; it's missing the Indian context. Global models trained largely in English fail to capture India's languages, cultural relationships, and societal nuances. Building indigenous models, even if early versions are imperfect, is essential to embed this context.

The first few iterations will be weak due to talent and funding constraints, and startups alone can't build foundation models. But with patience, successive iterations can reach open source competitiveness. These models are especially critical for sovereign use cases such as defence, government, healthcare, and finance, where data control and jurisdiction matter. Expectations must be realistic, but the strategic value is undeniable.

Q. Is India's funding sufficient to build a global AI ecosystem?

A. Not really. Compared to global peers, India lacks true risk capital for exploratory and long-horizon AI research. While the government has taken a positive step by committing over a billion dollars in GPU subsidies, private funding in India is largely growth- and profitability-driven. Investors are hesitant to back experimental or "esoteric" AI work, and there is still concern about an AI bubble. As a result, India is unlikely to compete head-on in the large foundational LLM race, which requires massive, sustained risk capital. However, that is not where our strength lies. Applying AI to specific, real-world problems, often using smaller, task-focused models is a much more achievable and impactful opportunity. India can lead in applied AI across education, governance, citizen services, and industry use cases. We may not win the LLM arms race, but we can build meaningful, scalable AI solutions that the world can learn from.

Q. Can India compete globally under open source sovereign AI pressure?

A. We cannot compete by copying Western approaches or spending at the same scale. Platforms like DeepSeek show that innovative architectures such as mixture-of-experts models can achieve high performance at much lower cost than brute-force methods like ChatGPT. India's path lies in thinking differently: developing new mathematical models or approaches that solve the same problems without replicating the West's resource-intensive methods. Limited resources force us to innovate, leveraging brains over muscle. Inspiration from countries like China shows that ingenuity can overcome scale limitations, and that's the model India should follow.

Q. Any message to academicians and students preparing for new AI-driven opportunities?

A. The real gap is not students or courses, it is trainers. Almost every college today talks about AI and new technologies, but the challenge is whether faculty have real, up-to-date industry knowledge. AI is evolving daily, and even the industry is still learning, which makes standardised teaching difficult in the short term.

The most urgent need is to train the trainers; give faculty exposure, hands-on experience, and continuous upskilling so they can pass relevant knowledge to students. Without that, courses remain theoretical and disconnected from industry needs. Preparing educators is the key to preparing students for the AI future.

Q. Will AI eliminate coding jobs, and where does human value remain?

A. AI coding assistants are already changing how software is built. They can generate applications and content

quickly, improving our productivity by over 40% while also standardising code and improving documentation. This will reduce hiring needs and impact repetitive, "bot-like" coding roles. However, AI will not build complex applications on its own; human judgment, architecture, and problem-solving remain essential. The biggest risk is for developers who resist adopting these tools. Those who adapt and use AI as a co-pilot will stay relevant; those who don't will be the first to be replaced.

Q. How should professionals identify if they are falling behind?

A. The clearest sign is resistance to change. But this should be recognised through exposure, not judgment. It is important to avoid early or age-based bias. The issue isn't age, it's whether you stay current. Seeing what's happening globally makes the gap obvious. When people realise AI is being used for things like drug discovery and advanced design not just chatbots, it becomes a wake-up call. Continuous learning and exposure to real-world innovation are the only ways to avoid falling behind.

Q. How do you personally balance leadership, learning, and life?

A. Weekdays are for my hobbies; weekends are for my obligations. Saturdays and Sundays are structured around family, parents, and everyday responsibilities. During the week, work is something I genuinely enjoy. Our organisation is mature, so my leadership team knows their responsibilities. I do formal reviews only two days a quarter; the rest of the time, they approach me if needed. That gives me flexibility to focus on learning, customers, and staying technically relevant. If I am advising customers, I need to truly stay up to date. **END** 🐼